

Hiking Diary

Haute Route



Long-distance hike through the Valais Alps – joining in La Sage in the Val d'Hérens, from July 19, 2026

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Stage 1 – Sunday, July 19 – La Sage, Col du Tsaté, Cabane de Moiry

The opening stage of our Haute Route – and straight into the discipline that defines this trek: crossing from one valley into the next over a high pass. The classic stage starts down in Les Hauderes (the Komoot plan says 13.2 km, 1,923 m of ascent, 7:10 h) – we joined in the mountain village of La Sage instead, saving ourselves the first 400 vertical metres on tarmac and meadow paths. That still leaves a good 11 km with around 1,650 m up and 500 m down: through larch forest to the alpine huts of the Tsaté, over the 2,868 m pass and along the glacier forefield to the Cabane de Moiry on the far side.

Tip: Starting in La Sage instead of Les Hauderes is perfectly legitimate – the PostBus stops right in the village (“La Sage, village”). You will want those saved vertical metres for the final pull up to the hut in the afternoon.

Start in La Sage (1,667 m): The little village clings to the sunny flank of the Val d’Hérens, high above Les Hauderes – all around are the sun-blackened timber houses and granaries (mazots) typical of the Valais, perched on round stone “mushroom” discs to keep the mice away from the grain. Beyond the last houses the trail starts climbing immediately, first across meadows, then through open larch forest.



Final act before the climb: travel shoes off, hiking boots on – at the edge of the path between the first granaries of La Sage.

Alpage du Tsaté (approx. 2,170 m): Above the forest the terrain opens up and you suddenly step into another century: the du Tsaté alpage is a cluster of a dozen low stone huts roofed with heavy stone slabs – cattle are still summered up here today. A large Swiss flag hangs on one of the huts, and behind it the view runs down the whole Val d'Hérens to the peaks on the far side.



The du Tsaté huts with their stone-slab roofs – and the obligatory Swiss flag. From here it is still a good 700 vertical metres to the pass.

Col du Tsaté (2,868 m): The crossing from the Val d'Hérens into the Val de Moiry, a side valley of the Val d'Anniviers. The last half hour grinds through scree and rubble, but the reward at the top is all the greater: on the far side an entirely new mountain world opens up – the first meltwater lakes of the glacier forefield shimmer in the green basin below, and behind them the three-thousanders around the Glacier de Moiry stack up.



Looking east from the Col du Tsaté: the basin with the forefield lakes below, our descent path winding down the scree flank.

Lac de Moiry: On the descent from the pass the reservoir appears below to the right – a turquoise so unreal you first suspect a photo wallpaper. The colour comes from finely ground rock flour (“glacial milk”) that the Glacier de Moiry washes into the lake. The 148 m arch dam at the northern end was completed in 1958; the water feeds the power stations of the Val d’Anniviers.



Lac de Moiry (2,249 m) and its dam – the turquoise is real, no filters involved.

The traverse to the hut: Instead of dropping to the lake, the trail contours high above the head of the valley towards the south. Below, the glacier forefield spreads out: the milky-turquoise Lac de Châteaupré, braided meltwater streams, freshly polished rock slabs – and above it all the Glacier de Moiry pushes its shattered icefall into the valley. The final stretch follows the bare crest of the moraine – ice to the left, scree to the right, the hut straight ahead on its rock bar.



On the high trail: Lac de Châteaupré and the braided meltwater channels below, the Glacier de Moiry to the right.



On the moraine crest just before the hut – behind us the meltwater cascades out of the icefall.

Cabane de Moiry (2,825 m): The hut of the SAC Montreux section sits on a rock bar directly above the icefall of the Glacier de Moiry – you can hardly get closer to a glacier on foot. In 2010 the old stone house of 1924 received its striking extension: a dark steel structure with floor-to-ceiling panorama glazing, so you look straight onto the séracs over dinner. We make it up before the afternoon mist rolls in – time for tea, a card game and the first hut evening of the trek.



The Cabane de Moiry: the 2010 extension with its panorama glazing on the left, the icefall on the right – the terrace benches are front-row seats.



Made it – proof shot in front of the hut, stage 1 done.



Arrived: tea on the terrace, the card game already waiting – outside, the afternoon mist drifts across the glacier.





Closing time at 2,825 m: boots off, crocs on – the glacier view is part of the evening programme.

The icefall up close: From the hut's rock bar it is only a few steps until you stand face to face with the Glacier de Moiry. Where the ice breaks over the rock step, the séracs pile up into a chaotic labyrinth of towers and crevasses, and below them the meltwater plunges in white cascades over the polished rock. The freshly exposed patches of bare rock in the middle of the ice show mercilessly how much the glacier has retreated in recent years.



Below the icefall the meltwater shoots over the rock step – its roar accompanies the whole hut evening.



Séracs in detail: where the glacier flows over the steep step, the ice tears into towers the size of houses.



Good night in the dormitory – the next stage is waiting tomorrow.

Tip: The Cabane de Moiry books out quickly in summer – reserve half board well in advance. And pack light hut shoes (or crocs): hiking boots stay downstairs in the boot room.

Stage 2 – Monday, July 20 – Cabane de Moiry, Lac de Moiry, Zinal

After the hut evening by the glacier, today is the opposite: a pure descent day. The plan says 16.2 km, 6:15 h, a mere 605 m of ascent – but 1,757 m of descent, down from the Cabane de Moiry (2,825 m) into the Val d'Anniviers to Zinal (1,675 m). We followed the route exactly as planned: a short stretch of ridge first, then down to the reservoir, across the dam, and down long switchbacks through the forest to Zinal.

Tip: On descent days like this one, trekking poles earn their keep – 1,750 m downhill takes a real toll on the knees. It also pays to start early: the morning ridge still lies in shadow before the sun heats up the whole descent.

Setting off in the morning: Just past the hut the trail still crosses a stretch of rocky terrain before swinging down towards the lake – in the low morning light the whole basin still lies in shadow, only the peaks opposite already glow. Ahead of us on the ridge, a party apparently roped up for a glacier or firn crossing – a scene from another decade, a reminder that in this terrain high-alpine routes and perfectly ordinary hiking trails often run just metres apart.



Looking back across the morning ridge – the roped party in the distance wasn't our group, apparently headed for a more demanding objective.



Shortly after setting off, at the highest point of the traverse below the Sasseneire (3,254 m): one more look back before the trail turns decisively downhill.

Back at the Lac de Moiry: From above, the reservoir looks quite different again from the day before – the turquoise water framed by the bare moraine slopes at the head of the valley. The descent leads straight to the 148 m arch dam that has held back the lake since 1958.



Lac de Moiry from a new angle – from above, on the way down from the hut.



On foot across the dam – behind us the head of the valley with its peaks, ahead the final push down into the valley.

Rest stop at Morette: Beyond the dam the trail drops through long switchbacks into larch and arrolla pine forest – a noticeable change after two days above the treeline. At the Morette junction, surrounded by flowering fireweed, we take the first proper break since breakfast. A small car park marks the lowest point here that you could also reach by road – for us, just a rest stop, not a destination.



A well-earned rest at the Morette junction – half the vertical metres are done, but there is still a good 1,000 m further downhill to Zinal.

Arrival in Zinal: From Morette the descent continues through the forest for quite a while before the gradient finally eases and the valley opens up. Zinal (1,675 m) is the highest village in the Val d'Anniviers, ringed by an imposing crown of four-thousanders – including the Weisshorn and the Zinalrothorn – and traditionally a starting point for high-alpine climbs as much as for the Haute Route. After 1,750 m of descent, the first order of business in the village is accordingly simple: put your feet up.



Recovering on a café terrace right in the village – all around, the usual summer scene of a Valais mountain village: slate-roofed chalets and the cantonal flag with its 13 stars in the wind.



The view from our lodging: clouds still sit low in the valley basin, only clearing towards evening.

Fondue to finish: After two days of trail food from the backpack, the end of the first half of the trek calls for what you always crave in the Valais – cheese fondue, with bread, pickled onions and gherkins.



The well-earned dinner: fondue in the caquelon – after 1,750 m of descent, thoroughly deserved.



After dinner the sky finally clears – a view of one of the striking peaks at the head of the Zinal valley.

Tip: Zinal has several grocery shops and a good choice of restaurants – after two hut nights, a welcome chance to restock supplies for the coming stages.

Stage 3 – Tuesday, July 21 – Zinal, Forcletta, Gruben

After the pure descent day into Zinal, today is a classic pass day again: from Zinal (1,675 m) up to the Forcletta (2,874 m) and down the other side to Gruben (1,829 m) in the Turtmanntal – the plan says 17.2 km, 7:05 h, 1,218 m of ascent, 1,055 m of descent. We followed the route exactly as planned. The Forcletta is the traditional link between the Val d’Anniviers and the Turtmanntal and is one of the standard stages of the Chamonix-to-Zermatt Haute Route.

Tip: Gruben itself has only one historic hotel with limited capacity – worth booking well ahead, or doing what we did and taking a room in the next village by car instead.

Climbing out of Zinal: The trail first climbs steeply out of the Zinal basin through open larch forest, past the slopes above St-Jean, with recurring open views back into the Val d’Anniviers. Only gradually does the forest thin out, opening onto the bare high terrain of the pass.



Climbing through larch forest – the view back into the valley opens up further with every metre of height gained.

Forcletta (2,874 m): Above the treeline the terrain turns bare and wide open, ringed by rugged three-thousanders. The Forcletta itself is a broad, unspectacular saddle – but with a panorama in both directions: back into the Val d’Anniviers, ahead into the Turtmantal. Exactly the right spot for a well-earned break at the top.



Refuelling at 2,874 m: Valais dried meat, cheese and bread – one of the simplest and best pass-top meals of the whole trek.

Arrival in Gruben: The descent from the Forcletta into the Turtmanntal is noticeably gentler than the climb out of Zinal. Gruben itself is a handful of houses around a single, long-established hotel – for generations the only place to stop for miles around, and a fixed point on the route between Zinal and the Augstbordpass. The terrace is properly busy in the afternoon: hikers and a few older guests over coffee and cake, the mountains of the Turtmanntal behind them.



Afternoon calm on the terrace in Gruben – after 1,218 m of ascent, a very welcome institution in the middle of the Turtmanntal.

On to Oberems: With no beds left in Gruben itself, we continue by vehicle after the break to Oberems, high above the Rhone valley between Turtmann and Leuk. From the accommodation the view drops far down onto the valley floor with its vineyards and orchards, the peaks of the Bernese Alps hazy in the distance beyond.



Evening view from Oberems down into the Rhone valley – a panorama you wouldn't necessarily expect from this stage of the route.

A curiosity along the way: The door of the village shop “Konsum Oberems” provides some amusement – in Switzerland “Stossen” is simply the normal instruction for pushing a door open, but to German ears it is unavoidably a little cheeky.



“Stossen” – a Swiss classic that German-speaking hikers love to trip over.

Stage 4 – Wednesday, July 22 – Gruben, Augstbordpass, Jungu, Randa, Europaweg

A day with two very different halves. Part 1: on foot from Gruben (1,829 m) over the Augstbordpass (2,894 m) down to the car-free hamlet of Jungu (12.5 km, 5:50 h, 1,164 m of ascent, 1,003 m of descent), then cable car down and onward by the Mattertal railway to Randa. Part 2: from Randa on the Europaweg up to the Europahütte – only 3.9 km, but 860 m of ascent in 2:35 h, with virtually no counter-descent. We covered both parts exactly as planned, whether on foot or by transport.

Tip: Best to check the cable car and train timetables between Jungu and Randa in advance – connections aren't especially frequent, and missing one costs valuable time on an already long day.

Over the Augstbordpass: From Gruben the trail first climbs through the upper Turtmanntal, then switchbacks up to the Augstbordpass. At the top, a bare high plateau covered in scree and boulders awaits, dotted with small meltwater pools – the Augstbordpass traditionally links the Turtmanntal with the Mattertal and is one of the classic stages of the Chamonix-to-Zermatt Haute Route.



Bare pass terrain at the Augstbordpass – scree, a small pool, low morning sun.

Jungu and the cable car: On the north side of the pass, the descent leads to the small, car-free hamlet of Jungu – there's no road access here, only a small cable car down into the Mattertal. The ride through steep forest, with snow-capped peaks in the background, is a welcome break for the legs.



Down from Jungu by the small cable car – the only connection this car-free hamlet has to the valley.

By train to Randa: From the top station above St. Niklaus, the view drops far down onto the village on the valley floor, with the tracks of the Matternal railway running right through it. Instead of walking the whole valley floor on foot, the train takes over from here up to Randa – a welcome shortcut that saves the legs for the steep afternoon ahead.



Looking down on St. Niklaus in the Mattertal – from here the train carries us onward to Randa.

Randa and the Europaweg: In Randa (1,407 m) the second, short but punchy part of the day begins: the Europaweg, a spectacular balcony trail high above the Mattertal with views of the north face of the Weisshorn and, further on, the Matterhorn. In just 3.9 km it climbs 860 m – with almost no let-up.

Charles Kuonen suspension bridge: The afternoon's highlight and thrill in one – the 494 m long suspension bridge spanning the Grabengufer ravine up to around 85 m above the ground. It opened in 2017 after the previous bridge was damaged by a rockfall, and at its opening it was the longest pedestrian suspension bridge in the world. It sways noticeably in the wind – for anyone comfortable with heights, one of the most spectacular views on the entire route.



Halfway across the suspension bridge – the Grabengufer below us, nothing but air all around.

Arrival at the Europahütte: Beyond the bridge the climb on the Europaweg continues a while longer until the Europahütte (2,220 m) is reached – a well-earned stage destination after a day of a pass, a cable car, a train and one of the most spectacular bridges in the Alps.

Tip: The suspension bridge is not for anyone with a pronounced fear of heights – it sways noticeably in the wind, and there's no way to step aside on the narrow structure.

Stage 5 – Thursday, July 23 – Europahütte, Weingarten Glacier, Täsch Hut

The plan was a detour: from the Europahütte down to Täsch, by bus up to Täschalp, and on foot onward to the Täsch Hut (18.2 km, 9:10 h, 1,950 m of ascent, 1,514 m of descent). We deviated instead and walked straight over the Weingarten Glacier – a high-alpine alternative that skips the detour through the valley, but is noticeably steeper. Around two hours longer than the plan, but by our own judgement thoroughly worth the extra time: very steep, but beautiful.

Tip: The Weingarten Glacier variant is not something to decide on the spur of the moment – glacier experience and suitable equipment should be planned in advance, and the two-hour time buffer over the valley route should be budgeted for firmly.

Across the Weingarten Glacier: Instead of the detour through the valley, the route leads straight across glaciated high-mountain terrain – wild rock and ice scenery, far from the valley trails used by other hikers. The effort pays off with every view.



In the middle of the glacier crossing – nothing but rock, ice and ridges all around, not another hiker in sight.

Highest point with a view of the Matterhorn: At the highest point of the crossing sits a bizarre cluster of stone slabs standing on end – whether trail markers or simply the work of bored hikers remains an open question. The view reaches as far as the Matterhorn, pushing through the clouds on the horizon to the left.



Rock formations at the highest point – and far to the left on the horizon, small but unmistakable, the Matterhorn.

Arrival at the Täsch Hut: After the long descent from the high point we reach the Täsch Hut (2,701 m) – two hours later than planned via the valley route, but with impressions that thoroughly justify the detour.





Arrived at the Täsch Hut – worn out, but very happy with the detour.

Evening at the hut: The evening can hardly be introduced any better than with a glass of Valais Merlot on the terrace – the view drops down into the valley, the first clouds already turning gold.



First glass on the terrace – after a day on the glacier, thoroughly earned.

A short walk above the hut leads to a white stone statue on a cairn – a so-called mountain Madonna, a type of figure found fairly often in the Alps at passes and hut approaches, often placed as a patron protector for climbers and hikers.



Mountain Madonna above the hut, in the evening light in front of the glaciers at the head of the valley.

The sunset takes its time – contrails cross over the peaks, the clouds glow in ever-changing colours.





The head of the valley in the last light – one of those evenings where you can hardly take your eyes off the mountains.

Inside, meanwhile, a card game provides a cosy end to the evening, along with another glass of wine.



Cards and wine to close out the day – the classic hut evening.

A curiosity at the hut: A notice for the “Kochende Männer Täsch” (Cooking Men of Täsch) hangs at the Täsch Hut – a festival restaurant association you really wouldn't expect up here. No connection to today's route, just a funny find along the way.



Found at the hut: the guest card of the “Kochende Männer Täsch” – whatever that's for.

Stage 6 – Friday, July 24 – Täsch Hut, Täsch, Journey Home

The last day: an unspectacular, pure descent from the Täsch Hut (2,701 m) down to Täsch (1,450 m) – no pass, nothing special happening, simply reaching the destination. After five days of passes, a suspension bridge and a glacier crossing, a quiet way to close things out.

Journey home: From Täsch the train takes over for the journey home – down the Mattertal and onward towards home, with the last peaks that felt so close over the past days sliding past the train window.

In summary – six days on the Haute Route: From La Sage in the Val d'Hérens to Täsch in the Mattertal, over four passes (Col du Tsaté, Forcletta, Augstbordpass, and, in place of the valley route on the last day, the Weingarten Glacier), past the turquoise Lac de Moiry, across the Charles Kuonen suspension bridge, and through the Valais from one end to the other – a trek with tremendous variety: glacier forefields, forests, reservoirs, car-free hamlets and lonely high-alpine trails. Along the way we deliberately deviated from the planned routes twice (the shorter start in La Sage, the glacier variant on day five) – both times with excellent results. An adventure that was worth it in memory just as much as in the photo book.
